

Yes, this is the politics talk. Come!

What did I originally want to talk about today?

- The neuroscience of understanding code –
can we work better with current LLMs?
- My experiments with building a tech team who are
mostly empowered by Claude Code

What I'm talking about?

~~How~~ Why does one get into Indian politics?

Why?



Why?

Bihar

- Population: 130 MM, 16 MM under 5
- 43% stunted; 120,000 severely acute
- Nutrition rehabilitation center: 38 (1 in 100 sq km)
- 10-20 beds, 2 weeks. Max capacity: 500

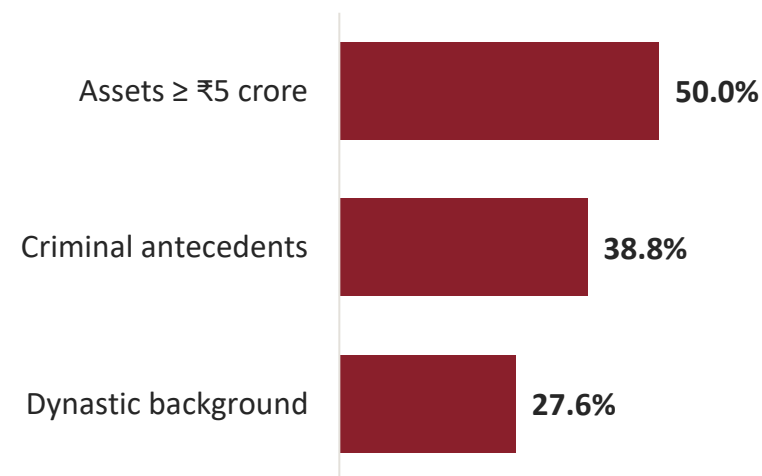
Who gets a ticket?

Across 768 candidates fielded by the BJP and INC for the 2024 Lok Sabha, a ticket went overwhelmingly to people who already had money, a family name, or a criminal case behind them.

- 56.9% vs 40.1% — share of BJP vs INC candidates holding ₹5 crore or more in assets
- Just 13.4% of tickets went to women — and 80.6% of them were gatekeepers too

76%

of BJP + INC candidates carried a strong gatekeeping marker: dynasty, ₹5 crore+ in assets, or serious criminal charges



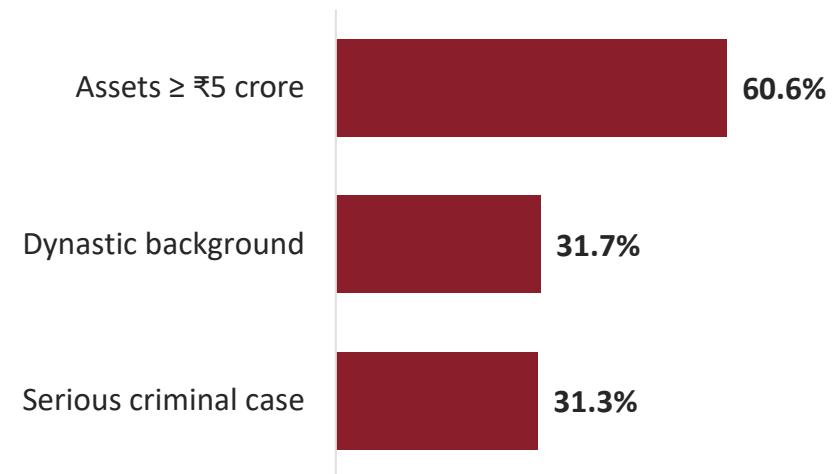
Who wins an election?

Of the 543 MPs elected to the 18th Lok Sabha, most crossed the finish line on privilege rather than merit alone — carrying money, a family name, or a criminal case with them into Parliament.

- 20.4% of MPs are self-made — no dynasty, no ₹5cr+ in assets, no serious case
- Among the 74 women MPs, 63.5% are dynasts and 97.3% clear even the loose privilege bar

79.6%

of MPs have a strong-privilege bar. Broken down, that privilege is:



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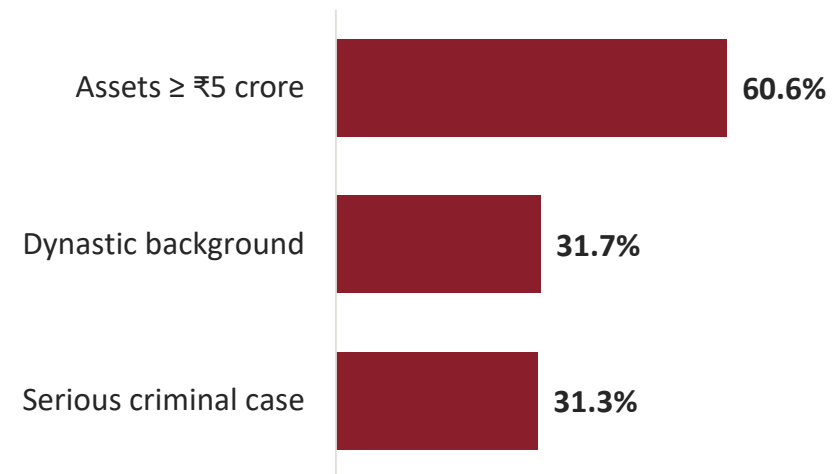
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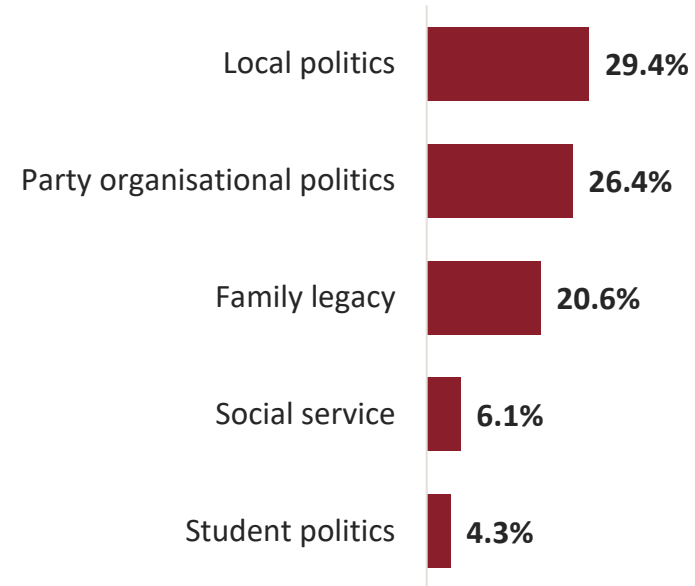
Routes to becoming a politician

Which door do most first-time politicians actually walk through? Tracing 327 elected MLAs across Telangana, Chhattisgarh and Punjab back to their first move, the busiest ramps are unglamorous — local bodies and party organisational work — not student unions or protest movements.

- Student politics is just 4.3% of entries — bans on student-union elections and privatised campuses shrank that pipeline. But 85.7% of those who did use it were already privileged: caste networks and money increasingly decide who wins campus politics itself
- A dynast's first win comes at median age 43 vs 47 for a non-dynast
- a four-year head start

55%

of seats are held by gatekeepers under the loose test: a dynastic background, any criminal case, or assets of ₹5 crore or more



What's the “average” path today?

How does one get into Indian politics?

How does the avg young person think about it today?



What's the “average” path today?

Money.

Example of an alternate model:

- Mamdani and the support provided by NYC

What's the “average” path today?

Team building.

- How is this different from political consultants?
- Team of rivals

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Team_of_Rivals

What's the “average” path today?

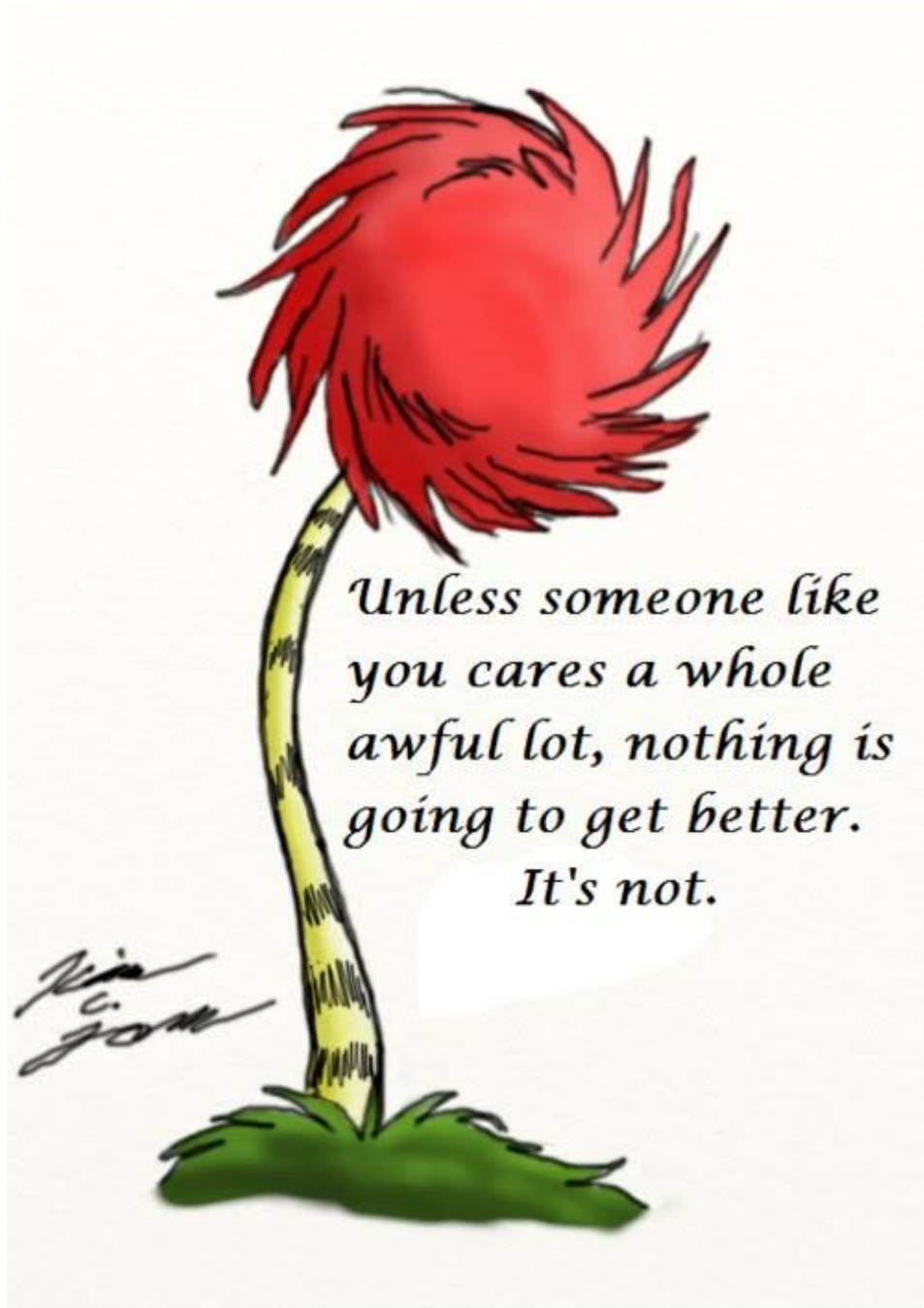
Hard fork

- People
- Technical skills

What's the “average” path today?

Some hope:

- An example of a race to the top
- Which party to join? Independents?



Remember,

Politics is standing up for a way of life you believe in.

Politics is not political office

You can be involved in politics without aspiring to get into political office.

<https://shashank-srikant.github.io/>

Who becomes a CM?

Mapping all 31 sitting Chief Ministers across every state and Union Territory into four career pathways — Pioneer, Dynast, Loyalist, Opportunist — shows staying loyal to one party for decades beats founding one or inheriting one.

- In the BJP, 66.7% of CMs are Loyalists — zero are Pioneers or Dynasts
- Among regional parties it flips: 89% are Pioneers or Dynasts, zero are Loyalists
- The party-switcher route has more than tripled since 2014
- from 2 CMs to 9

45.2%

of CMs are “Loyalists” who never left one party’s ecosystem — only 12.9% built their own party from scratch

